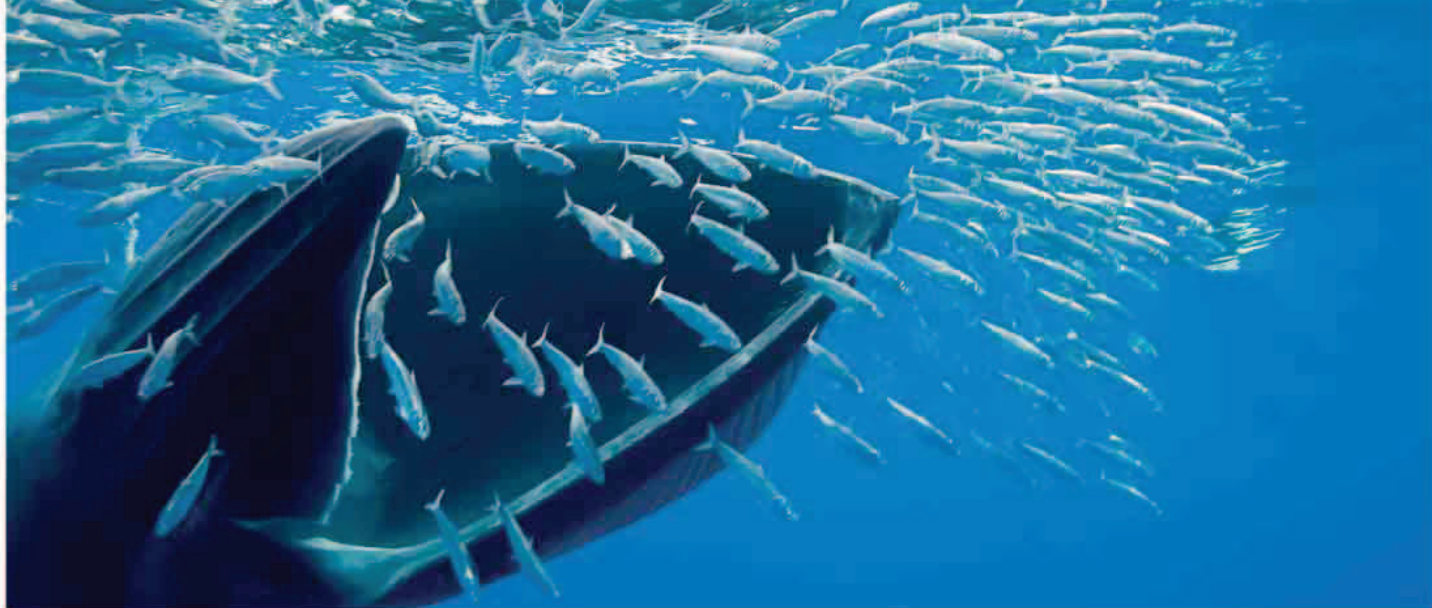
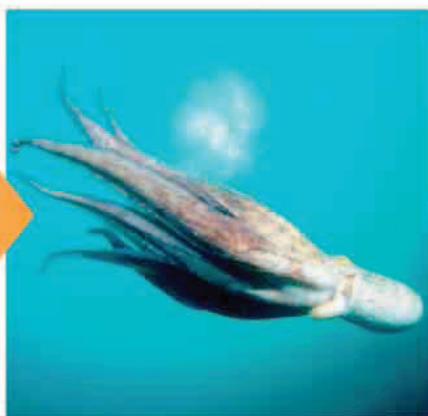




▲ BIG MOUTHFUL

A school of small fish try to escape the gaping jaws of a hungry Bryde's whale. It could easily swallow the entire school in one mouthful.



▲ HUNTER

A crab makes a perfect meal for this octopus. It digests the meat and turns it into nutrients and energy. But the octopus may get eaten too.



▲ TOP PREDATOR

A big, powerful shark might eat the octopus. But the shark has no serious enemies, so it is at the top of the oceanic food chain.

SHORT CUTS

Some big oceanic animals short-cut the food chain by targeting very small animals. They include giant filter-feeding whales, which eat small fish and shrimplike krill instead of hunting bigger prey such as tuna. The whales get to eat more this way, because the smaller animals lower down the food chain are much more numerous than the tuna, and easier to catch. This is one reason why these whales—and other giant filter feeders like the manta ray—can grow so big.

AN OCEANIC FOOD WEB

Simple food chains such as the one shown above are unusual, because many animals eat a variety of prey from different parts of the chain. Even top predators are eaten by other animals when they die, and these include tiny worms and snails. So in practice most living things are part of a complex food web, rather than a chain. This diagram shows a simplified food web for the Arctic Ocean, from phytoplankton to polar bear and killer whale. The arrows go from prey to predator in each case.

